

DESIGN THINKING

Canteen Seating Availability issue

Suki, Rawdha, Jason, Cheng Yang, Rafi

DHS - 3

Observation: Data Analysis

Table 1. Canteen Analysis during peak hour (lunch and dinner)

Canteen	Qing Fen Canteen	Halal Canteen
Number of Seats	400-500 seats	80-100 seats
Time needed to find a seat	2 minutes	10-20 seconds
Time needed to que	3-10 minutes (depends)	1-2 minutes



Our results demonstrate that the number of students per canteen is not optimized.

Observation: Repeated Behaviour

based on the same analysis, we also found another repeated behaviour around both canteen:

Qing Fen Canteen	Halal Canteen
When they're alone, they can usually place their bags on the chair. However, sometimes, it is so crowded that some people hang their bag or put it in between the chairs.	When they're alone, they always able to put their bags on the chair
As a group, they often choose to hang the bag. Only in the worst case scenario we can see people putting in on the ground.	As a group, they sometimes put it on the ground. There are times where they can even put it on other table's chair, as there is still some space.

Our results demonstrate that the number of students per canteen is not optimized.

Discover

Define

Develop

Deliver

Why do students stay in the "crowded" zone?

It's not just about hunger; it's about value (Special menus like roasted duck) and location.

So displacing the students **is not the solution.**

What is the problem here?

Methodology

To ensure we get the best data, we conducted 2 methodologies:

Primary Method: Shadowing (Live Analysis)

- The Process : We tracked 3 students from the moment they entered the canteen until they took their first bite.
- The Goal : To map the "pathing" and decision-making process of students in different canteen environments.
- Metric Captured : "The Hunt" duration (Time spent circling for a seat).



Secondary Method: Comparative Contextual Inquiry

- The Environments : Side-by-side analysis of Qingfen Yuan (High Density) vs. Halal Canteen (Low Density).
- Focus : How does bag placement behavior change as the room gets more crowded?

30% Capacity Loss

In peak hours at Qingfen, we observed that roughly 1 in 3 chairs was occupied by a bag or used as a "social buffer," not a person.

Discover

Define

Develop

Deliver

What We Heard

High Anxiety & Defeat

vs

What We Saw

High Anxiety & Defeat

"I can never find a single seat... there are always hundreds of people."

"It's a headache when I'm in a hurry and there's nowhere to sit."

"The waiting line for special menus (10+ mins) makes the seating hunt feel even more urgent."

The "Bag-on-Seat" Maneuver: Students immediately "claim" territory with bags to protect them from the greasy floors.

The Social Shield: At 4-person tables, solo diners place bags on adjacent chairs to create a personal bubble and avoid eye contact with strangers.

The Tray Taker: Students wandering in circles for 2+ minutes with heavy, hot trays, increasing congestion in the aisles.

Finding: Students complain about a lack of seats, but their behavior shows they are actually struggling with a lack of hygienic storage and personal space.

*Refer to previous slide picture

Discover

Define

Develop

Deliver

Say

"Is this seat taken?" "I'll wait in the roasted duck line."

Do

Bag Drop, Table Joining (reluctant), Tray Balancing.

Think

"The floor is too greasy for my laptop bag," "I don't want to sit too close to a stranger."

Feel

Anxiety, Frustration, Protective (of personal space/belongings).

Discover

Define

Develop

Deliver

Our personas

The Solo Efficiency Tracker

A

**Needs a quick "clean gap" for a 30-min lunch.
Stressed by "ghost seats" (seats with bags).**

The Space Guardian/Group Member

B

**Wants a social "clean zone" for friends. Uses the
"Bag Drop" to mitigate the 10-minute wait time
for special food.**

Discover

Define

Develop

Deliver

The 'whys'

**Why the seats are full
during peak hours?**

Because many bags are placed on
the seats during peak hours

**Why students would put
their bags on the seats?**

To occupy the seats/Simply because
they don't want their bags get dirty on
the ground

**Why they don't want their
bags get dirty?**

Because they value their own
belongings

**Why they want to place
their bags near themselves**

Because they don't trust
others, comparatively.

**Conclusion: We actually have a storage
and hygiene shortage that manifests as a
seating crisis**

Discover

Define

Develop

Deliver

POV statement

Students at Qingfen canteen need a clean, personal space for themselves and their belongings without social disturbance because the 'bag-on-seat' culture, driven mainly by hygiene concerns and a desire for social buffers, partly by safety issues, has created a false 'crowded' space that increases seating anxiety and social embarrassment for everyone.

Discover

Define

Develop

Deliver

How Might We?

How might we provide a 'clean zone' for belongings that unlocks the seating capacity currently lost to bags?

How might we make the floor feel safe for personal items?

How might we redefine table boundaries to make sitting with strangers feel less intrusive?

How might we "nudge" students to prioritize seating efficiency without sacrificing their comfort?

DESIGN THINKING

Thank You!

DHS - 3